

1. Can you describe your role in relation to the student research projects you have been involved in or supervised?

I was a student project lead within the Value Chain Hackers Lab. I was responsible for coordinating the project work, keeping contact with stakeholders, and making sure that the research activities were done as agreed. I did not supervise other students in a formal way, but I did take responsibility for planning, communication, and follow-up within the team.

2. At the start of projects, what guidance are students typically given about how they are expected to document their research work? Can you give an example?

At the start, they said we should put our work somewhere shared, so that was fine. I did not really think too much about it beyond that. I focused on doing the actual work and making progress. Things like notes from conversations or small observations, I mostly kept in my head or in my own files, because I felt I knew what was relevant. For me, the important part was the final outcome and whether the solution made sense, not writing everything down along the way.

3. Can you describe specific situations where documentation came up during project work with students? What happened in those moments?

Documentation usually came up when someone was missing context. For example, when a stakeholder asked why a certain choice was made, or when a supervisor joined later in the project. In those moments, we noticed that decisions were discussed verbally but not always written down, so we had to reconstruct the reasoning afterwards.

4. Based on the final outputs of projects, how usable do you think they are for someone new who has not spoken to the original student team? Can you give an example?

Someone new could understand what we were working on, but it would probably take time to see how we got there. A lot of ideas developed through discussions and working sessions, and those steps are not always visible in the files. You see the result, but not everything that led up to it.

5. Which parts tend to be difficult for someone new to understand based only on what is written down or stored?

The link between the stakeholder conversations and the concepts might be hard to follow. We discussed many things as a team before shaping them into the final ideas, and not all of those discussions were captured. Without that background, some choices are probably unclear.

6. Can you think of an example of an important decision or change during a project, and describe how and where it was documented, if at all?

Yes. In our project, we changed the focus of the research after the first interviews. This was discussed in meetings and agreed with the stakeholder, but it was mainly documented implicitly in later versions of the research question.

7. If someone new wanted to understand how one important conclusion of a project was reached, what would they need to look at or read?

They would need to look at multiple things. The final report, the interview notes, and possibly emails or meeting notes. But these are often stored in different places, so it takes effort to connect them.

8. During projects, is it clear who is responsible for documenting what, if anyone? How is that responsibility typically communicated or decided?

We never really defined responsibility for documentation. Everyone kept track of their own work, but there was no shared approach for organizing it. Since our focus was mainly on developing the concepts, documentation was not something we structured as a team.

9. What tools, templates, or systems are students expected to use to document work, and where is everything actually stored in practice?

We were expected to use tools like Word and Google Docs and to store documents on something shared like GitHub or a Google Drive. In practice, it was more a collection of people's personal notes and files on their own devices that were later brought together when needed, rather than a central place.

10. What do you think the purpose of documentation is in these projects? Who do you think benefits from it, if anyone? And what, if anything, influences how motivated students are to document their work well?

I would assume to offer clarity on the project and the process we undertook. Supervisors, future students, and stakeholders benefit from it. Students are more likely to document when they see the point in it, if it feels like an extra task instead of part of the submission process i'm not sure how likely they would be to do that.

11. Based on your experience, what tends to get lost most often over time across projects, for example context, decisions, data, analysis steps, or contacts?

Over time it becomes less clear how the ideas developed. You can still see the final concepts, but the earlier discussions and intermediate thinking are less visible. That makes it harder for someone else to understand how the project progressed.

12. How does documentation fit into project work from your perspective? Does it seem integrated into the work, or more like something added on top? Why?

At the start we were mainly focused on developing the concepts, so documentation was not something we discussed much as a team. It became more relevant once we had to organize the material, but there was no fixed way of doing it during the project.

13. From your perspective, what currently makes it difficult to achieve consistent documentation across projects, and what would need to be in place for research outputs to be considered trustworthy and usable over time?

What makes it difficult is unclear expectations and lack of structure. To improve this, there should likely be clearer guidelines and expectations and a single system where everything is stored. Also, documenting decisions during the project would help.

14. Is there anything about documentation, continuity, or research practice that we have not discussed but that you think is important?

I think continuity between projects is important. Often, projects build on each other, but knowledge is not transferred well. Better documentation would help new teams start faster and avoid repeating the same mistakes.